ANNOTATOR GUIDELINES · VERSION 1 · 24 SEPTEMBER 2026

# Forced Alignment

German `de_DE`

**How to use this guide.** Parts 1–4 apply to all languages. Part 5 has the German rules; where they differ from Parts 1–4, Part 5 wins.

`Pending` = not final yet; this guide will be updated.


1. Your task
2. Segment rules
3. The tool
4. Writing the text
5. German rules
6. Checklist before you submit


## 1 · Your task

Each task is one audio file that a machine has already cut into word segments. Every segment has a **start time**, an **end time** and the **text of one word**. The machine makes mistakes: check every segment and correct it.

1. Listen to the audio.
2. Check every segment: **timing** — does it start and end exactly with the word? **Text** — is it exactly what was said, written the way this guide says?
3. Fix every error: move edges, correct the text, split, merge, add or delete segments.
4. Answer the two task questions: more than one speaker? Overlapping speech?
5. Discard the task if a discard reason applies (2.6).
6. Submit.

## 2 · Segment rules

### 2.1 What one segment is

**German:** one segment = one space-separated word. Compound words stay whole (`krankenhaus` = 1 segment). Details: Part 5.

### 2.2 Boundaries

- Start the segment where the word's sound begins. End it where the sound stops.
- End where the **speech** stops, not where the waveform ends. If the tail is silence or noise — even if you still see amplitude — pull the edge back to the last real speech. Same at the start.
- In fluent speech words blend and there is often no silence between them. Listen carefully and use judgment to find where one word ends and the next begins.
- A segment whose start and end are equal (zero length) is an error: give it the word's real length.
- **Segments from the same speaker must never overlap.** Overlap is allowed only between different speakers (2.4).

### 2.3 What to fix

| PROBLEM | FIX | EXAMPLE |
|---|---|---|
| Segment starts too early or ends too late | Move the edge | Starts 40 ms early → move the start to the word's onset |
| Zero-length segment | Give it its real length | Start = end → extend the end |

| PROBLEM | FIX | EXAMPLE |
|---|---|---|
| Wrong text | Correct the text (Part 4) | Type the word that was actually said |
| One segment holds two or more words | Split: one segment per word | `das ist` → `das` `ist` |
| Letters said one by one are joined | Split: one segment per letter | `ard` → `a` `r` `d` |
| A filler sits inside another word's segment | Split | `ich` → `äh` `ich` |
| One word is spread over several segments | Merge into one segment | — |
| A spoken word has no segment | Add a segment | — |
| Segment covers only silence or background noise | Delete it | Segment over silence → delete it; add the word where it is really said |
| Segment covers only a cough, laugh, breath or other non-word sound | Delete it | — |

## 2.4 Speakers and overlap

For every task, answer: **Is there more than one speaker? Is there overlapping speech?** In the tool: *Multi-speaker* and *Overlap speech* (Part 3). Overlapping segments must belong to different speakers.

## 2.5 Special cases

**Entirely synthetic speech (text-to-speech)**

- Mark it only when you are confident the **whole file** is computer-generated. Leave the transcription empty. In the tool: dustbin button (top right).
- Signal: a perfectly fluent, native-sounding voice that makes mistakes a fluent human would not — mispronounced words, misread numbers or abbreviations, stress on the wrong part of a word.
- Mistakes by a non-native speaker or a child are normal human speech — not a signal.
- Not sure? Do not guess — transcribe it.
- Human and synthetic speech in one file (e.g. a person talking to a bot): do not mark it. Transcribe normally and set the synthetic speaker's **Nativity** to **TTS**. Pending where Nativity is set in the tool.

**Garbled or distorted part** (you cannot tell whether it contains words)

- Not pre-segmented → leave it; add no segments there; transcribe the rest normally.
- Pre-segmented, **fewer than 20** segments in that part → delete them, add **one** segment `(())` covering the part, continue with the rest.
- **20 or more** segments in that part → discard the whole task.

**Unintelligible and guessed words**

- Speech you cannot make out → `(())`. A guess → the guessed word in double brackets: `((krankenhaus))`. Whole file unintelligible → discard.
- Misspoken non-word, but you know or can guess the intended word → the intended word in double brackets. Use sparingly — only when what was said has no correct spelling.
- Only for the main speakers. Never transcribe background speech.

**Another language in the audio**

- Transcribe and segment it if you can, with that language's normal spelling (script rules: Part 5). Its presence alone is not a reason to discard.
- If you cannot transcribe or segment any part of it — even a small part — discard: *Non-target language*.
- Never transcribe other-language speech in the background.

## 2.6 Discard

In the tool: dustbin button (top right), then choose one reason from the drop-down.

Audio not loading · UI Issue · No audio · No voice activity · Non-lexical sound only · Non-target language · Sensitive content · Unintelligible

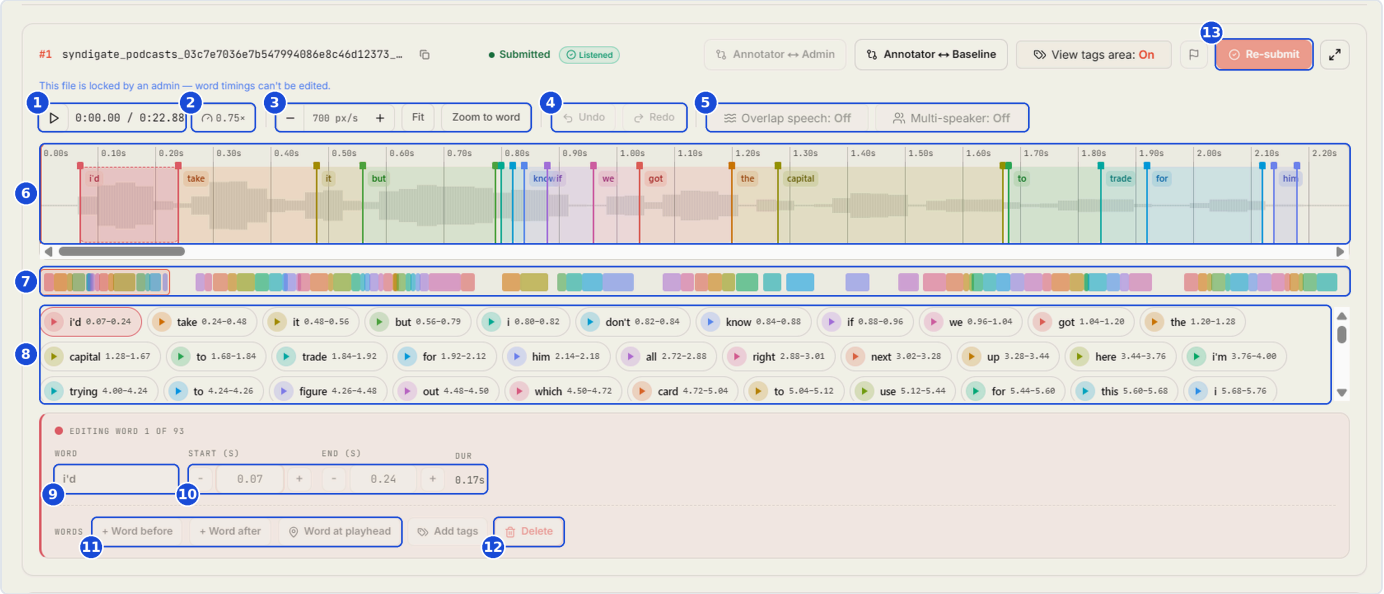
| SITUATION | REASON |
|---|---|
| Audio is distorted or garbled; no intelligible speech | Unintelligible |
| Only cross talk (no main speaker, or the main speaker is unintelligible because of it) | Unintelligible |
| Main speaker entirely unintelligible — only `(())` possible, not even guesses | Unintelligible |
| Only humming or other non-word sounds; no words | Non-lexical sound only |
| Sensitive content | Sensitive content |
| Other-language speech you cannot transcribe or segment | Non-target language |
| The file contains only an extremely cut-off word | Discard — reason **Pending** |
| Garbled part with 20 or more segments | Discard — reason **Pending** |

**Pending**

- Which discard reason to choose for the two cases marked Pending above.
- Where a speaker's Nativity (TTS) is set in the tool.

# 3 · The tool

All languages use the same tool.




| # | CONTROL | WHAT IT DOES |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Play ▶ and time | Plays the audio; shows current time / total length. |
| 2 | Playback speed | Speed of playback (here 0.75×). |
| 3 | Zoom − / +, Fit, Zoom to word | Zoom the waveform in or out, fit it to the view, or zoom to the selected word. |
| 4 | Undo / Redo | Undo or redo your last change. |
| 5 | Overlap speech / Multi-speaker | Turn on when speech overlaps / when there is more than one speaker. Adds a speaker layer to the timeline, where you assign each segment to Speaker 1 or Speaker 2. |
| 6 | Waveform | Each coloured block is a segment. **Drag its left or right edge** to change its start or end. |
| 7 | Overview strip | All segments in the file at a glance. |
| 8 | Word list | Every segment with its start–end time; ▶ plays it. The highlighted one is being edited. |
| 9 | Word | Text of the selected segment. Edit it to correct the text. |
| 10 | Start / End (s), Dur | − / + nudge the start or end time. Dur is the segment's length. |
| 11 | + Word before · + Word after · Word at playhead | Add an empty segment before or after the selected word, or add a segment where the playhead is. |
| 12 | Delete | Removes the selected segment. |
| 13 | Submit (top right) | Submits the task. Shows "Re-submit" here because this file was already submitted. |

Not in the screenshot: the **split** and **merge** buttons · the **dustbin** button, top right (discard, or entirely synthetic speech) · the speaker layer (appears when 5 is on) · keyboard shortcuts (listed in the tool).

### How to do each fix

| TO… | DO THIS |
|---|---|
| Change a start or end | Drag the segment's edge on the waveform (6). Fine-tune with − / + next to Start or End (10). |
| Correct the text | Select the segment and edit the Word field (9). |
| Split a segment | In the Word field, put a space at each split point ( `das ist` ), then press the split button. You get one segment per space-separated part. Drag each new segment's edges into place. |
| Merge segments | Use the merge button to join the pieces into one segment. Then check its text and both edges. |
| Add a missing word | Select the word next to it and use *+ Word before* or *+ Word after* — or put the playhead on the word and use *Word at playhead* (11). Type the word, then drag its edges. |
| Remove a segment | Select it and press *Delete* (12). |
| Mark speakers or overlap | Turn on *Multi-speaker* and/or *Overlap speech* (5), then assign each segment to its speaker in the new layer. |
| Discard the task | Dustbin button (top right); choose the reason from the drop-down. |
| Mark entirely synthetic speech | Also through the dustbin button (top right). |
| Undo a mistake | *Undo* / *Redo* (4). |
| Finish | *Submit* (13). |

# 4 · Writing the text

## 4.1 Basics

- **Spoken form:** write what the speaker actually said, as they said it — not a cleaned-up written version.
- **Latin letters:** always lowercase.
- **No punctuation**, except: an apostrophe that is part of a word ( `'ne · nich'` ); a hyphen marking a cut-off word ( `kranken-` ); an optional period after a spelled letter ( `a. r. d.` ).
- **Numbers:** always as words, never digits. Write the number in its standard written form, remove hyphens, and give each space-separated word its own segment. Examples: Part 5.
- **Spelling:** the reference dictionaries in Part 5.

## 4.2 Hyphenated words

- Remove the hyphen; each part is its own segment: `e-mail` → `e` `mail` · `baden-württemberg` → `baden` `württemberg` .
- This applies to all hyphenated words, including names, places and brands. Only exception: the hyphen that marks a cut-off word.

## 4.3 Cut-off words and self-corrections

- Write as much of the word as you hear and put the hyphen where it is cut: `kranken-` (end cut off) · `-kenhaus` (start cut off). The cut-off word gets its own segment around the part you can hear.
- Only slightly clipped but fully audible → write the whole word, no hyphen ( `krankenhaus` ).
- Do not add a hyphen to a complete word just because the audio starts or ends there.

- The file contains only an extremely cut-off word → discard.
- Self-correction that cuts a word → hyphen: `spiel das li- lied`.
- Repetition or correction without a cut → no hyphen: `navigiere zum zum hotel` · `ruf anna an nein ich meine hanna`.
- Interrupted while spelling letters → write only the letters said. No hyphen after a period.

### 4.4 Letters and acronyms

- Letters said one by one → one segment per letter; a period after each letter is optional: `a` `r` `d` or `a. r. d.`.
- Acronym said as a word → one segment: `nato`.

### 4.5 Fillers and backchannels

- Fillers (äh, ähm) and backchannels are words: each gets its own segment. Multi-part ones are split: `mm hm` → `mm` `hm`.
- Use the German spellings in Part 5.
- Coughs, laughs, breaths and humming get no segment.

### 4.6 Homophones

Choose the spelling from context. If the word is said on its own, choose the one more likely to be said on its own.

### 4.7 Names and brands

Same rules as everything else: lowercase Latin, hyphens removed, letters split when spelled out. Examples in Part 5.

# 5 · German rules

de_DE

**One segment = one space-separated word.** Compound words are one word → one segment, however long: `geschwindigkeitsbegrenzung` `krankenhaus`. Never split a compound.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Dictionaries** | Duden (duden.de) → DWDS (dwds.de) → Merriam-Webster for English words. |
| **Letters** | All lowercase — nouns too. Keep **ä ö ü ß**; never write ae, oe, ue or ss instead. |
| **Spoken reductions** | Write as heard: 'ne / ne (eine) · 'n / n (einen, ein) · hab (habe) · is / iss (ist) · nich / nich' (nicht) · mal (einmal) · 's (es) · wa / wa' (oder, as a tag question). |
| **Numbers** | German writes a number as one word → one segment: `siebenundachtzig` (87). |
| **Fillers & backchannels** | äh (hesitation, open vowel) · ähm (hesitation, lips closed) · mm hm → `mm` `hm` (agreeing; not "mhm") · tja · ach (surprise) · genau · naja |
| **Homophones** | seite (page) / saite (string): seite is far more common · leib / laib: context · waise / weise: weise more common alone · mehr / mär: mehr more common. |
| **Names & brands** | `youtube` · `gronkh` · `bibisbeautypalace` (as spoken) · ARD → `a` `r` `d` when spelled out, `ard` when said as a word. |
| **Other languages** | English words keep their English spelling (code-switching with English is common). |

**Pending**

- The spelling of the thinking sound (hm) is not final yet.
- Spoken fusions such as haste, kannste, aufm and gibt's are not covered yet.
- Hyphenated words are split ( e-mail → `e` `mail` ) but solid compounds are not; which spelling to use when Duden allows both.

# 6 · Checklist before you submit

- ☐ Every word has exactly one segment; compounds are not split.
- ☐ Every segment starts at the word's first sound and ends at its last; no zero-length segments.
- ☐ No segment covers only silence, noise, coughs, laughs or breaths.
- ☐ The text matches what was said and follows Part 4 and Part 5.
- ☐ Multi-speaker and Overlap speech are set correctly; overlapping segments belong to different speakers.
- ☐ If the task must be discarded, or is entirely synthetic, you used the dustbin button.